



Members of a Chechen militant group speak to journalists inside a theater in Moscow, during a standoff with Russian troops.



THE EURO BECAME LEGAL TENDER

at the start of the year when 12 countries in the **Eurozone** (see 1999) abolished their individual currencies.

Slobodan Milosevic, the former Yugoslav president, went on **trial** on February 12, charged with **crimes against humanity**. He chose to defend himself, and the trial faced many delays due to his ill-health. Milosevic died in 2006, before the trial was completed.

President George W. Bush of **America** and President Vladimir Putin of **Russia** agreed to cut numbers of nuclear warheads by two-thirds each in the **Treaty of Moscow**, signed on May 24.

In Moscow, a gang of heavily armed **Chechen militants** besieged a theater on October 23,



and threatened those inside if Russia did not withdraw from Chechnya. Russian special forces pumped gas into the building before engaging the rebels in a gun battle—118 people were killed.

A **nightclub** on the Indonesian island of **Bali** became the target of a terrorist attack in which more than 200 people died.

Common currency

*A new currency for 12 members of the European Union, the **Euro**, was launched in January 2002. It has since become secure as global tender.*

Members of a violent Islamist group, **Jemaah Islamiyah**, were convicted of the attack.

US-led forces began the first large-scale campaign against the **Taliban** in Afghanistan—**Operation Anaconda** began in March.

The US journalist **Daniel Pearl** was kidnapped in January in Karachi, Pakistan. Pearl was investigating extremist Muslim groups. His ransom demanded the release and return to Pakistan of prisoners from Guantanamo Bay, a US prison camp in Cuba. Pearl's body was found in May.

India and **Pakistan** came close to war in May, following a major terrorist attack on the Indian parliament in 2001, which India claimed was carried out by Pakistan-based militant groups fighting Indian rule in **Kashmir**, north India. Both countries positioned troops either side of the international border with Kashmir.

Tamil rebels signed a **ceasefire** with the Sri Lankan government in February as part of a Norwegian-led initiative that ended 19 years of civil war.

Meltdown

*A massive chunk of Antarctica's **Larsen ice shelf** broke up in 2002—it lost a total of about 1,255 sq miles (3,250 sq km).*



Sierra Leone in West Africa emerged from a decade of civil war with the help of a strong diplomatic and military presence from Britain, its former colonial ruler.

The 26-year civil war in **Angola** ended in April when a **ceasefire** was agreed between the Angolan Army and UNITA (National Union for the Total Independence of Angola). The civil war had been ongoing since independence from Portugal in 1975.

The **African Union** replaced the Organization of African Unity in July. The new union was intended to reflect the different challenges facing the continent.

“WE, ...TRUE OWNERS OF THIS LAND, SHALL NOT BUDGE, THE LAND IS OURS.”

Robert Mugabe, president of **Zimbabwe**, December 2002

Robert Mugabe, president of Zimbabwe, ordered white farmers to leave as part of his policy on land redistribution to the black populace. The declaration was defied by many farmers.

US millionaire **Steve Fossett** became the first person to fly a balloon solo nonstop around the world. He completed the journey on July 2 in 13 days and 12 hours.

THE BEGINNING OF THE YEAR

was marred by tragedy when the US space shuttle **Columbia** **disintegrated** as it reentered the Earth's atmosphere. All seven crew members were killed. An investigation confirmed that a heat shield had malfunctioned on takeoff, causing it to break up upon reentry.

The last commercial flight of **Concorde**, the supersonic aircraft, was made in October. Concorde was given an emotional farewell at Heathrow airport in London, England. It had flown for 27 years but spiraling costs and dwindling ticket sales led to its demise.

Yugoslavia voted to end its existence in February, becoming **Serbia** and **Montenegro**. The Yugoslavian Federation had existed for 74 years, but had lost its other four republics in

Speedy exit

*The supersonic airliner **Concorde** retired in 2002. Concorde was an international icon and epitomized the advance of modern technology.*

